Put On and Check a Disposable Respirator

Use a genuine, NIOSH-approved disposable particulate respirator only when current public-health advice recommends one. Follow the instructions for your exact make and model.

× DANGER — STOP NOW

Know its limits. This respirator filters particles; it **does not supply oxygen** and does **not protect against gases or vapors**. Leave immediately for cleaner air if you feel dizzy, faint, nauseated, confused, or short of breath.

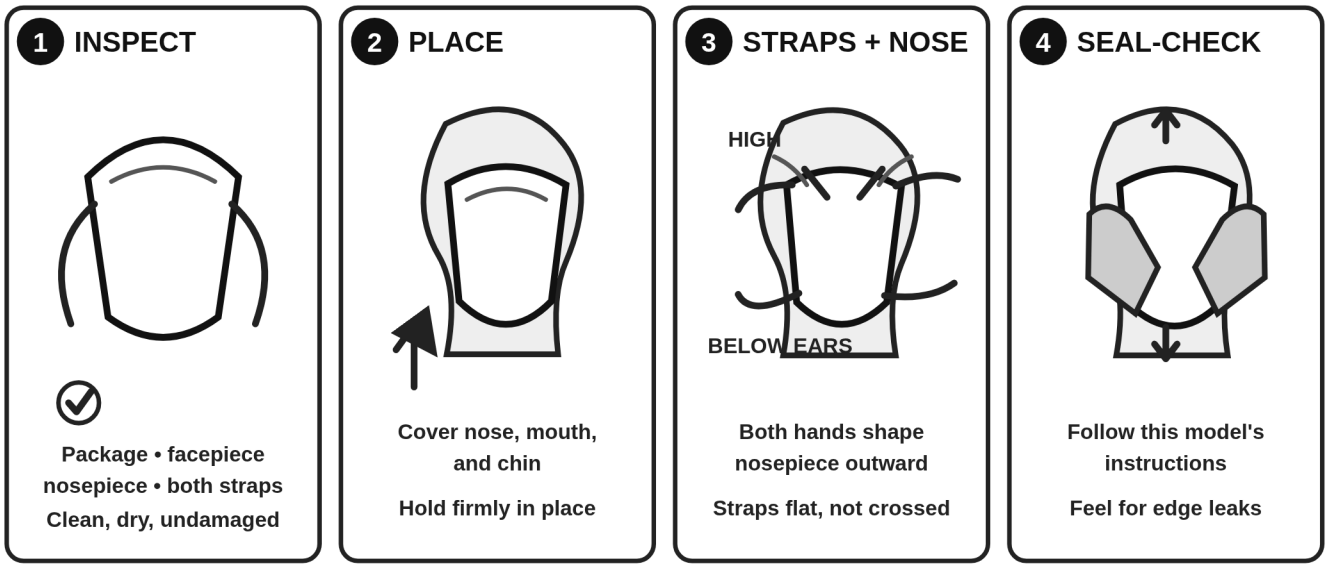
BEFORE YOU PUT IT ON

1. **Read the package.** Confirm the respirator is NIOSH approved, is the right model and size for you, and is within any marked shelf life. Find the model's donning and user seal-check instructions.

2. **Inspect it.** Use a clean, dry respirator. Check the facepiece, nosepiece, valves (if present), staples, and both straps. Do not use it if a part is missing, torn, stretched, cracked, soiled, or otherwise damaged.

3. **Clear the seal area.** Hair, jewelry, glasses, clothing, or anything else must not pass between skin and the sealing edge. Facial hair such as stubble, beards, or some mustaches can prevent a seal. Some face shapes or sizes may not seal with a particular model.

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Inspect → place → position and shape → seal-check. Strap locations and the seal-check method can vary; use the manufacturer's instructions for your model.
Original diagram based on NIOSH guidance; see asset manifest.

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PUT IT ON

1. **Place:** Cup the respirator in your hand with the nosepiece at your fingertips and straps hanging free. Cover your **nose, mouth, and chin**; hold it firmly against your face.
2. **Position both straps:** Pull the **lower strap below your ears, around your neck**. Pull the **upper strap high on the back of your head**. Keep straps flat and untwisted. Do not cross them or put both around the ears unless the manufacturer specifically directs that arrangement.
3. **Shape:** Using fingertips from **both hands**, press the nosepiece inward while moving outward along both sides of your nose. Do not pinch it with one hand; that can leave gaps.

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A user seal check is required every time you put on the respirator. It is not the same as a workplace fit test.

CHECK THE SEAL EVERY TIME

1. **Use the model-specific method.** Follow the package or manufacturer instructions. The method may be a positive-pressure check, negative-pressure check, or another specified procedure. Do not invent a method.

2. **Usually, cover the filtering surface** with both hands without crushing or shifting it. For a respirator with a valve, the instructions may tell you to cover the valve instead.

3. **Breathe as directed** by the manufacturer—often a gentle exhale, inhale, or both. Feel around the entire sealing edge, especially at the nose and chin.

Pass or fail?

Seal passes	Seal fails
The facepiece responds as the instructions describe, and no air leaks around its edges.	Air moves toward your eyes, fogs glasses, or leaks at the nose, cheeks, or chin; the facepiece shifts; or the model's check does not respond as described.

If it fails: adjust the nosepiece and straps, reposition the respirator, and repeat the same check. If it still leaks, try another NIOSH-approved model or size. **Do not enter or remain in smoky or contaminated air without a seal. Move to cleaner air and follow current local public-health advice.**

△ **CAUTION — PREVENT HARM**

Do not improvise. Do not knot, staple, cut, tape, or add material to the respirator to force a fit. Do not wear a second respirator over it unless its manufacturer specifically allows that use.

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Put On and Check a Disposable Respirator — continued

REPLACE IT—AND KNOW WHEN TO GET HELP

- **Replace and discard** the respirator when it becomes wet, dirty, damaged, contaminated, misshapen, or difficult to breathe through, or when its straps no longer hold a seal. Replace it whenever the manufacturer directs. Do not wash or disinfect a disposable respirator.
- **Children:** Adult respirators may not fit children, and NIOSH does not approve respirators specifically for children. A child who cannot obtain and maintain a seal should be moved to cleaner air; a caregiver should follow current local public-health and pediatric guidance rather than alter the respirator.
- **Breathing or heart conditions:** A respirator can make breathing harder. Ask a health-care professional before use if you have a breathing or heart condition, and follow current public-health advice. Remove it and seek cleaner air if breathing becomes difficult; seek urgent help for severe symptoms.
- **No seal:** Facial hair and some face shapes prevent an adequate seal with some models. If no available model seals, do not improvise. Reduce exposure, move to cleaner air, and contact your local public-health agency for current alternatives and instructions.

△ **CAUTION — PREVENT HARM**

Review required before distribution: This draft requires review by a qualified medical/public-health subject-matter expert and an editor. Local recommendations can change; check Los Angeles County Public Health and CDC guidance for the present event.

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SOURCES

Sources: NIOSH, *How to Use Your N95 Respirator* and *Particulate Respirators*; CDC, *Protecting Yourself from Wildfire Smoke*; Los Angeles County Department of Public Health, *Wildfire Smoke*. Accessed 2026-09-29.